

The Vaishali Lynchings

A VICTIM'S VIEW

In the face of police inaction, villagers of Dhelapurwa village in Bihar's Vaishali district brutally killed 10 men suspected of being thieves. Two of those involved now tell their story.

Ranjit Kureri, 20, the lone survivor of the Vaishali lynching that left 10 dead:

"It was almost 4 in the morning when we reached Dhelapurwa on our way to Tajpur Banjara village after attending a party. It was a long trek and some of us had drunk a lot of country liquor. We had no money but wanted a ride. We woke a three-wheeler driver but he turned abusive, after which one of us slapped him hard. The driver started shouting which attracted the villagers. They were angry and wanted to know who we were. Despite our best efforts we failed to convince them. In a couple of minutes a few young villagers started heckling and shoving us. We were frightened and some of us tried to escape. The villagers caught us and started beating us with whatever they could lay their hands on—stones, bricks and sticks. Our cries seemed to only provoke them more as they continued beating us for what must have been almost two hours. I escaped because I pretended to be dead. The police found me and took me to a hospital. It was later that I learnt we were suspected of being thieves and 10 of my companions had been beaten to death."



A PERPETRATOR SPEAKS

A burly man in his forties, who admits to being one of the Dhelapurwa attackers:

"There had been thefts in the village for the past six months. There were three burglaries in a fortnight, yet the police took no action, and so we started patrolling the village on our own. Initially, walking under the night sky was fun but soon enough, we grew irritable. Who likes to miss a good night's sleep? All we desperately wanted was to catch a thief and when we caught a pack of them, we meted out justice then and there. We never meant to kill them. We were only interrogating them, slapping them lightly, when some tried to escape. So we caught them and beat them with bricks and bamboos till they died. The police never paid any attention to our complaints so we have no remorse that we took the law into our hands. It was not planned. Nobody instigated us. We were just angry and frustrated. There seemed no other option. Although we are not inhuman, I must admit, some of us actually enjoyed the lynching. At least we got rid of these criminals. Our only regret is that one thief survived and another escaped."

As told to Amitabh Srivastava

reported in 2005, the city's riot cases have risen to 87 in 2006. The city's notorious 'Blueline' buses have claimed the lives of 96 this year; when a bus mowed down seven people in early October, the crowd tried to set the bus on fire but was teargassed by the police whom it pelted with stones.

And then, there is Bihar. The code its citizens borrow their punishments from belongs to the jungle. It began with Bhagalpur where a petty thief was first beaten by the crowd and then dragged by a police motorcycle. On September 13, 10 men accused of stealing at Dhelapurwa in Vaishali district were lynched by villagers. In Bettiah, two men attempting to kidnap the son of a local jeweller were beaten to death. In Nawada, three men accused of stealing bicycles were caught by bystanders; one was blinded with screwdrivers and sulphuric acid, and

the other two received serious injuries. In the same week Nawada's villagers beat two minors for stealing detergent and then paraded them on the streets with tansured heads.

Every incident from rural Bihar is underpinned by issues of caste, class or religion. Each also reflects the distance between India's two selves: global and local, urban and rural. But when viewed with the eruptions of violence in the cities, the incidents reflect a pan-Indian impatience with the institutions meant to ensure law and order, and to dispense justice—the police, the judiciary and the government.

Parmod Kumar, director, Institute of Development and Communication, a Chandigarh-based policy think tank, says the public's "grievance redressal mechanism" has collapsed, "Particu-

larly in the north and the east, which are afflicted with poor governance, the intervention mechanism at political and bureaucratic levels has become ineffective and the culture of protest has been pushed to the margin."

A mob by definition is born by the mutual raising of tension and comes together only to commit an act of violent protest. When it can be manipulated, it becomes a dangerous and uncontrollable beast. In a crowded, chaotic and conflict-ridden country like India, mobs are born more frequently today because an already overloaded and overcompromised judicial system continues to operate in an overheated climate watched by an over-eager media audience.

The domino effect of mob violence cannot be underestimated, specially as it is observed that perpetrators of public lawlessness are rarely identified or